media claimed that forces were working to attempt to ferment revolution and cause internal disruptions within the state. The hype went as far as to accuse the protesters of terrorism supported by the West, most notably the United States. The regime's next move was to cut communication services by deactivating landlines and mobile phone services of key activists' locations. A further step was taken to establish military tribunals at Insein prison to retaliate against several labor activists. Harsh prison terms were issued to multiple activists. The next step taken was to start counter protest by pro-government activists. Mass rallies were organized to celebrate the completion of the national convention. Attendance was mandatory in many areas of the country.

After the regime refused to meet the demands of the monks, the ABMA released a statement on September 14 that would have monumental implications. The monks excommunicated government officials through the overturning of the alms bowl. This process is known as *Patta Nikkujjana Kamma.* Peaceful protests were encouraged by the religious leadership.

The issuing of the boycott would have serious implications in such a predominately Buddhist society. The giving and receiving of alms is considered a vitally important act in Buddhism. The gaining of merit would be denied to the military and regime.

An important element of the boycott was the perceived threat to the legitimacy of the regime. For decades the SPDC and its supporters had sought to cultivate an image of protectors of the sangha. Part of the public relations apparatus of the regime was ceremonies that focused on merit making. Included in this would be gifts to monasteries, pagoda-restoration projects and numerous appearances with clergy, and the holding of the World Buddhist Conference. The boycott was a dangerous challenge to the regime, which was rarely seen in the modern history of Myanmar. On September 21, the ABMA issued a statement denouncing the military dictatorship as the enemy of the citizens. The alliance called for the evil regime to be banished from Burmese soil forever.

An earlier attempt in 1990 by the monks to combat the regime had led to dissolution of illegal monk organizations and unions, and a declaration that any monk who took part in nonreligious activities would be expelled from the sangha and imprisoned. Over 100 monasteries were raided in